



JNU CONVENTION CENTRE, NEW DELHI

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AI and Employability

Opportunities, challenges and the future of work: perspectives from industry, academia and India's skilling ecosystem

HOST

Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi

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ORGANISED BY

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This insights report distils the discussion at the Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series panel held at Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. It brings together views from a university dean, a professor of practice at IIT Delhi, a manufacturing CIO, national skilling leaders, a technology strategist and an AI educator, moderated by the Senior Editor of Education Times, The Times of India.

Quotes have been lightly edited for clarity. Figures are as cited by panellists during the discussion and have not been independently verified. The full recording is available on the AegisTV YouTube channel.

AT A GLANCE

AI and employability in India: the numbers behind the debate

India's graduates are qualified on paper, but the distance between a degree and productive work is wide, and AI is changing that distance faster than institutions are adapting.

8.69 months

Average time for industry to make a new employee productive

Cited by Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI

Up to 2 years

Before fresh AI hires deliver meaningful results in one manufacturing AI team

Cited by Parna Ghosh, Uno Minda

37%

Of work in the electronics sector estimated to be transformed by 2030

Cited by Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI

9.2 lakh

People skilled against a target of 10 lakh under the national AI skilling vision by 2025

Cited by Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI

1 crore

People to be skilled by 2030, the next target from the electronics sector's perspective

Cited by Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI

12

Start-ups identified under the IndiaAI Mission to build foundational models for India

Cited by Shreenivas Chetlapalli, Jade Global

Three messages from the panel

The gap is old, the urgency is new

Industry has always had to train graduates. AI raises the bar for what a new hire must do on day one, and shortens the time anyone can afford to wait.

India must move up the value chain

India is among the largest consumers of AI. The opportunity lies in research, models, products and enterprise-grade delivery, not consumption alone.

Every actor has a role

Universities, employers, skilling bodies, government and students each own part of the answer. No single actor can close the gap alone.

EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

From fear to a shared agenda

AI is often described as a threat to jobs, or even to humanity. This panel set the speculation aside and asked a practical question: are India's graduates, institutions and industries ready for work that AI is reshaping, and what must change?

An opening keynote set the stakes: India lost past contests to better cannons and better guns, and could lose the next one to better AI. The discussion, the second in the Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series, moved beyond individual career advice to the national picture: readiness for work, India's position in the global AI value chain, the state of skilling, and the long-running tension between services and products.

Panellists did not agree on everything. Some saw the readiness gap as structural and long-standing; others saw it as newly urgent. Some argued government must lead; others argued demand and capital must. That diversity of view is part of the value of this report.



"Opportunity exists, but real skills are not available. Media, industry, academia, everyone has to play a role."

Parna Ghosh, President and Group CIO, Uno Minda

KEY FINDINGS

- 1 Qualified is not the same as job-ready**
Graduates know the concepts, but industry reports months, sometimes years, before they deliver.
- 2 India consumes more AI than it creates**
Adoption is broad; research, models and product engineering remain the larger prize.
- 3 Readiness is sector-specific**
Some sectors are behind, electronics and manufacturing are just in time, semiconductors still have room.
- 4 Value lies in delivery**
Enterprise and agentic AI for everyday problems may offer India more than racing to build ever-larger models.
- 5 Reward questions, not answers**
With answers freely available, education must teach problem framing and inquiry.
- 6 Experience is the multiplier**
Mid-career professionals who pair domain depth with AI tools may drive the greatest real-world impact.
- 7 Products need demand and capital**
Domestic markets, patient capital and policy signals will decide whether India builds AI products.

THE PANEL

Eight perspectives across the ecosystem

The panel was designed to bring every part of the employability chain into one conversation: the university, the employer, the skilling system, the technology services industry and the AI educator.



Priyanka Srivastava

MODERATOR

Senior Editor, Education Times,
The Times of India



Prof. R. K. Brojen Singh

ACADEMIA

Professor and Dean, School of
Computational and Integrative
Sciences, JNU



Prof. Sougata Mukherjea

ACADEMIA

Professor of Practice,
Computer Technology, IIT Delhi



Parna Ghosh

INDUSTRY

President, Group CIO and Data
Protection Officer, Uno Minda



Madhvendra Singh

SKILLING

CEO, Electronics Sector Skills
Council of India (ESSCI)



Narendra Mohapatra

SKILLING

Former CEO, Electronics Sector
Skill Council of India



Shreenivas Chetlapalli

TECHNOLOGY SERVICES

Vice President, Technology and
Strategy, Jade Global



Bhupesh Daheria

AI EDUCATION

CEO, Aegis School of Data
Science & AI; Founder,
Assessfy



WATCH THE FULL DISCUSSION

AI and Employability: Opportunities, Challenges and the Future of Work

Panel discussion at Jawaharlal Nehru University, about 51 minutes, including audience Q&A
youtube.com/watch?v=y6hPsmX4u0w

IN THE ROOM

A conversation on campus



The panel in session at Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, moderated by Priyanka Srivastava of The Times of India.

The Campus Series takes the national conversation on AI onto campuses, where students, faculty and practitioners can question one another directly. At JNU, a meaningful share of the session went to the floor, and audience questions on India's product gap and on where to begin learning AI shaped two chapters of this report.

8

voices across
academia, industry
and skilling

51 min

of discussion,
including audience
Q&A



The panellists after the discussion, Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series, Jawaharlal Nehru University.

OPENING KEYNOTE

Better AI, or fall behind

Following the welcome by Prof. R. K. Brojen Singh, Bhupesh Daheria opened the session with a blunt reading of history: nations are not defeated for lack of knowledge, but for failing to build the next decisive technology.

EXHIBIT A A lesson from history, as framed in the keynote



THE MUGHAL ERA

Better cannons

India did not lose to the Mughals; it lost to better cannons.



THE COLONIAL ERA

Better guns

The British did not capture India; better guns did.



THE AI ERA

Better AI

If India falls tomorrow, it will be because it did not create better AI.

Source: keynote by Bhupesh Daheria, Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series, JNU.



“Societies, nations and companies fall not because they don't have the knowledge. They fall because they cling on to old success and old knowledge, and they don't innovate fast enough.”

Bhupesh Daheria, CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI

Talent without frontier models

India has deep AI talent: it has the second largest number of AI developers in the world, he said. Yet, in his assessment, India has produced no frontier models of its own.

The result is heavy dependence on Western technology, which leaves India with little leverage globally. He warned that this over-dependence is a problem today and will remain one unless India builds its own capability.

#2

India's global rank by number of AI developers

Cited in the keynote

0

Frontier AI models produced by India, in the speaker's view

Cited in the keynote

Resting on old glory. India invented zero, he noted, and keeps returning to that achievement. Past success is no substitute for innovating at the frontier now.



Watch the keynote

youtube.com/watch?v=Vfr3Rhr2RKI

OPENING KEYNOTE, CONTINUED

The mission and vision of Bharat AI Innovation

Having set out the stakes, Bhupesh Daheria explained why Bharat AI Innovation exists: to point India's AI talent at India's own problems, which, he argued, the Western world will not solve for us.

VISION

"Can we ignite the dream of 1.4 billion people with AI, and build solutions for us which the Western world will not, because they don't understand our problems?"

MISSION

"The whole motive of Bharat AI Innovation is to nurture companies, nurture talent, and start the conversation between academia, companies and researchers to solve real problems."



"We have literally got God in our hand, which is Saraswati, in the form of AI. Answers are everywhere. The only limiting factor today is: can we ask the right kind of questions?"

Bhupesh Daheria, CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI

WHOSE BHARAT?

By Bharat, he meant not the English-speaking metros but the majority of Indians who speak Hindi and other Indian languages and live in towns and villages, many still without basic services such as sanitation. His definition was one of language and geography, not politics.

WHY JNU

JNU has produced thought leaders and policymakers. Computer scientists alone cannot solve problems of governance, taxation, law and education; that needs cross-pollination between policy, economics, physics, chemistry and AI.

A vision of abundance

Looking further ahead, he argued that AI could create abundance. Over the next 50 to 60 years, he expects most major problems to be resolved: food for everyone, energy research that makes power nearly free, AI and robots doing much of today's work within a century, and even ageing approached as a disease to be solved.

1.4 bn

people whose problems Bharat AI Innovation wants AI to solve

50 to 60 yrs

his horizon for AI to deliver abundance

20 to 21 Nov

Bharat AI Innovation 2026, World Trade Center Mumbai

OPENING KEYNOTE, CONTINUED

Problems worth solving for Bharat

India's IT industry employs a few million people, he noted, but 1.4 billion people live with problems AI could help solve. Travel 50 to 100 km beyond Delhi or Mumbai and you find schools without teachers, bad roads and no healthcare.

EXHIBIT B Where AI can serve Bharat: examples from the keynote

Area	Example
Healthcare	Niramai, founded by Dr. Geetha Manjunath, screens for breast cancer using a thermal camera and AI, at a fraction of the cost of conventional detection equipment. The start-up has raised significant funding while widening access to care.
Child and women safety	Khozo, built by Aegis from 2017: a photo of a child found begging is matched against missing-child records, alerting the parents, the police station where the complaint was filed, the nearest police station and NGOs.
Examinations	Aarakshak, AI proctoring for examinations taken by millions of students, going beyond facial detection.
Justice	More than four crore cases are pending in Indian courts. Not all can be resolved by AI, but bright-line cases, such as camera-detected traffic violations, can.
Education and infrastructure	Schools without teachers, poor roads and missing sanitation, often within 100 km of major metros.
Governance	Taxation, law and public administration, where AI needs to be combined with expertise from policy and the social sciences.

Source: keynote by Bhupesh Daheria. Examples as described by the speaker.

The task changes, not the designation

Job titles are staying the same while the tasks beneath them change. His software engineers are still called software engineers, but he now tells them not to write code: deliver the software and let AI write the code, while they remain responsible for the result.

A new chance for core sciences

Thirty years of the IT boom, he argued, drained talent from civil, mechanical and electrical engineering, physics and chemistry. AI can now create new knowledge across all of them.

18 mo to 1 wk

Time to build a product that once took about a year and a half, now possible in about a week, in his recent experience

Cited in the keynote

KEY TAKEAWAYS

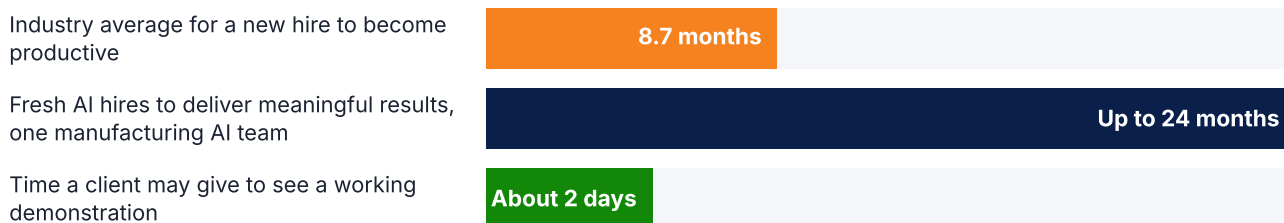
- Point AI talent at Bharat's problems, not only at IT services.
- Solutions need cross-disciplinary teams, not computer scientists alone.
- The binding constraint is no longer code but asking the right question.

01 THE READINESS GAP

Qualified, but not yet job-ready

Every panellist from industry and skilling described the same pattern: graduates arrive with sound concepts, but the path from concept to delivery is long and expensive for employers.

EXHIBIT 1 Time to productivity for new hires, against client expectations



Sources: Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI (8.69 months); Parna Ghosh, Uno Minda (up to two years); Bhupesh Daheria (client demonstrations in about two days). Figures as cited during the panel; the shortest bar is widened for legibility. Employers wait months for productivity while clients expect results in days.

What employers are seeing

- **Long ramp-up.** Parna Ghosh described her 14 to 15 member AI team at Uno Minda: concepts are clear, but meaningful delivery from fresh hires can take up to two years. Even external consultants often lack the required depth.
- **Few job-ready candidates.** Madhvendra Singh reported that, despite large skilling efforts, employers still find few people ready on day one, and that it takes an average of 8.69 months to make a new employee productive.
- **Certified, but mediocre.** He shared a blunt perception he hears from employers, and noted the rising number of young people not in education, employment or training.
- **Softer placement signals.** Prof. Sougata Mukherjea noted that while most IIT Delhi graduates still find jobs, some major companies have deferred joining dates or converted full-time offers into internships.

A different reading of the same gap

- **The gap is not new.** Shreenivas Chetlapalli argued it has existed as long as formal education in India. Student projects have moved from electronics to software to AI, and Indian readiness compares well with other countries, even if it is uneven.
- **Industry is not ready either.** Bhupesh Daheria argued that employers expect ready candidates, yet a strong graduate can become redundant within five years if industry does not keep skills current.



“People are qualified, they are doing AI. Are they ready up to the level the industry is looking for? Not yet. But there is a gap, and I am sure we will fill it.”

Shreenivas Chetlapalli, Vice President, Technology and Strategy, Jade Global

Learning cannot stop at graduation

Prof. Mukherjea placed the gap in historical context. When computers arrived, there was similar fear, and new kinds of work followed. AI coding tools can now write a complete program from a specification in about 30 minutes, something even strong graduates may struggle to match. Some roles, such as routine software testing, may shrink; new ones will emerge. The deciding factor, he argued, is whether people keep learning after their degree.



“Even someone who is fresh out of college should not think that is the end of their learning. They should continuously evolve.”

Prof. Sougata Mukherjea, Professor of Practice, IIT Delhi

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- The readiness gap is real and costly: employers absorb months of ramp-up for every hire.
- The gap is not new, but AI shortens the time employers and clients are willing to wait.
- Responsibility is shared. Graduates must keep learning, and employers must keep investing in skills after hiring.
- Placement signals are softening even at top institutions, through deferred joining and offers converted to internships.

SETTING THE CONTEXT

Moderator Priyanka Srivastava opened by naming the anxiety in the room: AI looks like a monster to many, and prominent voices abroad warn of existential risk. She set those speculative fears aside to focus on the concrete challenge of today, the changing dynamics of the job market. Bhupesh Daheria later urged the audience to discount fear-driven headlines, which he linked to political and business motives, noting that people have long lived safely with everyday risks such as a gas cylinder at home.

02 INDIA IN THE AI VALUE CHAIN

Consumer or creator?

India uses AI at enormous scale. The panel's harder question was where in the AI value chain India creates value, and where it simply consumes.

EXHIBIT 2 The AI value chain and India's position, as assessed by the panel

Research and innovation	New algorithms, architectures and mathematics. Much of this work is done by Indians, but largely abroad.	LIMITED
Chips and hardware	GPUs, semiconductors and compute. Focus on GPUs in India remains low; data centres are now being built.	LIMITED
Foundation models	Large language models. Sarvam and 12 start-ups selected under the IndiaAI Mission are building models for India.	EMERGING
Enterprise and agentic delivery	AI agents and enterprise models that solve day-to-day problems. Seen as India's strongest opportunity.	OPPORTUNITY
Applications and consumption	Use of AI tools for search, drafting, images and entertainment. A recent BCG report describes India as a leading consumer of AI.	STRONG

Source: Bharat AI Innovation analysis of panel discussion. Assessments are qualitative and reflect panellist views, not a measured index.

The consumption trap

Parna Ghosh used the iPhone as an analogy. India has become a major manufacturing and assembly base, but most of the value sits in research, design and product engineering, layers where India is still far behind. The same pattern risks repeating in AI.

Prof. Brojen Singh made a related point: many of the world's leading algorithms are developed by Indians working abroad. Why can that work not happen at home?

Build models, or deliver value?

Madhvendra Singh framed the strategic choice. Having started late, should India invest heavily in a sovereign large language model, or focus on the delivery layer: enterprise and agentic AI that solves everyday problems at scale?

Bhupesh Daheria added that scaling large language models is reaching its limits. The next breakthroughs will need new mathematics, and there India is not late.



"I think the real value lies in the delivery part: enterprise-level agentic AI and day-to-day problem-solving agentic AI."

Madhvendra Singh, CEO, Electronics Sector Skills Council of India

READINESS AND SKILLING

03 Sector readiness and the skilling value chain

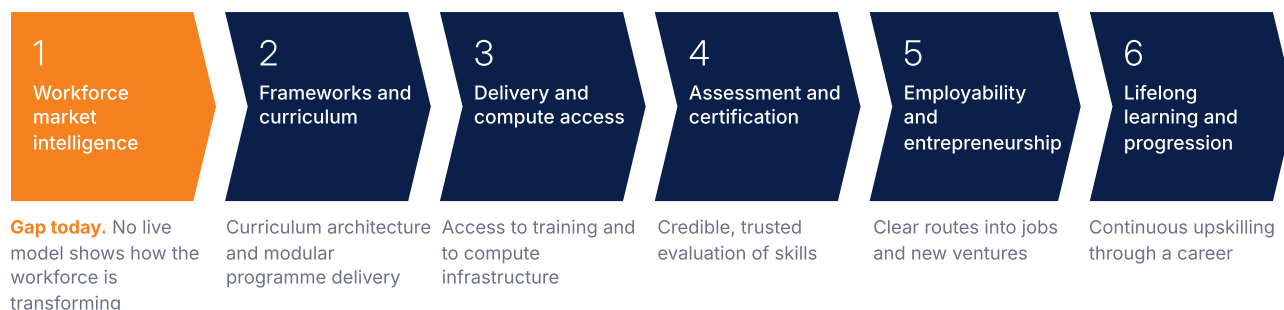
A single national verdict on AI readiness is misleading. Readiness differs sharply by sector, and skilling must be managed as a value chain, not a set of disconnected courses.

EXHIBIT 3 AI readiness by sector

Sector	Readiness	Panel view
Healthcare, pharma, BFSI	BEHIND	The window to start early has largely passed; catching up is now the task.
Electronics and manufacturing	JUST IN TIME	Large opportunity across manufacturing, quality, sales, research, engineering, finance and HR, if skills can scale.
Semiconductors	TIME TO BUILD	Still early enough to build capability deliberately.

Source: Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI; Parna Ghosh, Uno Minda. Qualitative assessment shared during the panel.

EXHIBIT 4 The AI skilling value chain



Source: framework presented by Madhvendra Singh, CEO, ESSCI.

Madhvendra Singh stressed that the chain starts with intelligence, not training. India has labour market information, but not workforce market intelligence: a continuous, industry-led view of how roles are changing. Without it, every later stage, from curriculum to certification, is built on assumptions.

EXHIBIT 5 The scale of AI skilling: progress and the next target



Source: Madhvendra Singh, ESSCI, as cited during the panel. The 2030 target is ten times the 2025 target; bars are drawn to scale.

What the numbers imply

- India came close to its first AI skilling target, showing that delivery at scale is possible.
- The next target is ten times larger, while about 37% of work in the sector is expected to change by 2030.
- Volume alone will not close the gap. Employers still report long ramp-up times, so quality, assessment and relevance must rise with scale.

A hard truth about colleges

Madhvendra Singh voiced, with care, a view he hears widely: that many colleges risk becoming places where employability is lost rather than built. Bhupesh Daheria went further, estimating that a large share of engineering colleges that operate as degree shops could close within a decade if they do not change.

Both views are presented as provocations from the panel, not as forecasts.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Assess and plan AI readiness sector by sector; a single national score hides more than it shows.
- Start the skilling chain with live workforce intelligence from industry.
- Credible assessment and certification are the hinge between training and employability.
- The 2030 ambition demands a step change in scale and in quality at the same time.

37%

of work in the electronics sector expected to be transformed by 2030

10x

increase in the AI skilling target between 2025 and 2030

92%

of the first national AI skilling target achieved by 2025

04 ACADEMIA How academia is responding

At JNU's School of Computational and Integrative Sciences, AI is no longer a subject for computer scientists alone. It is becoming a lens for every discipline.

AI across every discipline

Prof. R. K. Brojen Singh described a school whose faculty and students come from physics, chemistry, mathematics, biology, engineering and computer science. AI has been introduced into every course, alongside the Indian Knowledge System. Students who arrive with little exposure to data analysis, including biologists, learn to approach problems through AI and analytical methods.

He invited the industry panellists to engage further with the school, calling for closer, sustained collaboration between industry and academia.

EXHIBIT 6 Two ways to learn AI

MOST STUDENTS

AI as a black box

Trust the model and use it as a tool to solve day-to-day problems in one's own field.

FEW, MOSTLY PHD

Inside the algorithm

Study the mathematics and physics behind techniques such as neural networks, and improve their accuracy.

Source: Prof. R. K. Brojen Singh, Dean, School of Computational and Integrative Sciences, JNU.



"Get inside the algorithm, see the basic foundations of the mathematics, and see if we can bridge the gap to increase accuracy and predictability."

Prof. R. K. Brojen Singh, Dean, School of Computational and Integrative Sciences, JNU

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Embedding AI across disciplines widens the talent pool beyond computer science.
- Most learners will use AI as a tool; India also needs a deliberate pipeline of people who improve the tools themselves.
- Industry engagement must be structured and sustained, not limited to placement season.

05 QUESTIONS, AGENTS AND ENTERPRISE

From answers to questions

If AI can now perform even higher-order cognitive tasks, what is left for people to learn? Bhupesh Daheria's answer: the ability to ask the right questions, and the courage to build.

PROBLEM

- Academia still rewards answers, but answers are now available to everyone.
- Work once done by very large engineering teams may be done by a small fraction of them.
- He described this as the toughest campus placement season in three decades, with mass recruitment unlikely to return.

RESPONSE

- Teach students to frame questions and find problems worth solving.
- Look beyond IT to congested cities, roads, governance and public services.
- Learn to work with AI agents, which communicate in natural language and apply rules consistently.

OPPORTUNITY

- Building no longer needs large teams, offices or heavy capital.
- Models fine-tuned on Indian law and Indian problems can become valuable ventures.
- Software demand will grow, served increasingly by individuals and small teams.



“What students now need to learn is asking the right question, instead of academia rewarding answers, because answers are everywhere.”

Bhupesh Daheria, CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI

Governance as a proving ground

Because AI agents apply rules the same way every time, he argued, they are well suited to public services where discretion has historically created delays and leakage. Students can build systems for governance and public problems, trained on Indian law and Indian contexts.

India is not late

He noted that the transformer architecture behind today's large language models was co-authored by an Indian, Ashish Vaswani, and argued that the next generation of models will need new mathematics. The question is whether India can build an ecosystem where such talent creates at home.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

- Shift learning and assessment from recalling answers to framing questions and problems.
- Prepare graduates for self-directed careers and entrepreneurship, not only for campus placement.
- Point AI talent at India's own unsolved problems in cities, governance and public services.

06 SERVICES, PRODUCTS AND EXPERIENCE

Experience as the multiplier

Narendra Mohapatra challenged the assumption that young graduates will lead the AI transition. Real impact, he argued, will come from experienced professionals applying AI to problems they already understand.

- Tools have always changed, from slide rule to calculator to AI. The breakthroughs will come from mid-level professionals who pair practical knowledge with AI, so they must be trained to use it well.
- India has excelled in IT services but produced few global software products. Government can be a stimulant, but direction and ownership must come from society and industry.



"The real thing is how to apply practical knowledge through the tools and deliver it for the betterment of society."

Narendra Mohapatra, Former CEO, Electronics Sector Skill Council of India

EXHIBIT 7 Why has India built services, not products? Five views from the floor

PROF. SANJIV SARIN, AUDIENCE

Policy sends the signal

Past incentives favoured services over products and R&D. Government signals shape the whole industry, and India needs sovereignty across AI hardware and software.

A PANELLIST

Hardware is the missing layer

Focus on GPUs remains low. India should look end to end, from data centres and GPUs to models and applications.

PARNA GHOSH

India can build at scale

UPI shows that India can design, build and scale world-class technology for its own market. Lower-cost Indian models help democratise access.

SHREENIVAS CHETLAPALLI

Products follow demand and capital

Capital favours consumer start-ups with large domestic user bases. Deep-tech products lack a defined domestic market and patient funding.

PROF. SANJIV SARIN, AUDIENCE

Serve India first, then the world

Indian-built systems such as the Indian Railways passenger reservation system and the BSE BOLT trading system served India first and were later taken abroad. Strength at home is the route to export markets.

Source: audience question and panel responses. Positions are summarised and presented in the order raised.

07 LEARNING PATHWAYS

Where should a learner start?

An audience member asked a practical question: with agentic AI, prompting and many other branches, where should a student or professional begin? Two panellists offered complementary frameworks.

EXHIBIT 8 Three routes into AI

TOP-DOWN Build first Start by building a simple agent, such as one that replies to your emails. Curiosity then leads down to LLMs, transformers, deep learning and finally linear regression.	BOTTOM-UP Foundations first Start with statistics and basic mathematics, from $y = mx + c$, and build up to machine learning, deep learning and generative AI.	RECOMMENDED Hybrid Build something, go deeper, and repeat. Use AI to write code, but be able to explain every line, function and model choice.
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Source: Bhupesh Daheria, CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI.

EXHIBIT 9 Three levels of AI capability

Level	What to learn	Typical outcome
1. Literacy	Using generative AI and writing effective prompts for everyday work	Faster drafting, research and communication
2. Integrator	Working with APIs, LLMs, retrieval-augmented generation and small agents	Practical tools for day-to-day business use
3. Engineer	Building core systems such as facial recognition, medical detection and enterprise models	New products and deep technical capability

Source: Madhvendra Singh, CEO, ESSCI.

Why the teaching model changed

Bhupesh Daheria explained that he stopped asking students to avoid AI tools two years ago. Industry is in a hurry: clients expect demonstrations in days, not months. The new discipline is not avoiding AI, but understanding every line it produces.

Learning has been democratised

For the first time, he argued, anyone with a phone has access to near-limitless knowledge and the tools to build with it. The limiting factor is no longer access, but imagination and the willingness to pick up real problems.

RECOMMENDATIONS

An agenda for action

Drawing on the discussion, we set out priorities for each part of the ecosystem. None can close the employability gap alone; together they can.

Students and early-career professionals

- 01 Treat graduation as a starting point and keep updating skills.
- 02 Go beyond the black box: learn the mathematics behind at least one technique.
- 03 Practise framing questions and problems, not only finding answers.
- 04 Use AI to write code, but be able to explain every line.
- 05 Look at local problems as ventures waiting to be built.
- 06 Reclaim time lost to phones and social media.

Universities and educators

- 01 Embed AI across every discipline, not only computer science.
- 02 Assess problem framing and reasoning, not recall.
- 03 Build structured, year-round partnerships with industry.
- 04 Create a research pipeline that improves AI itself.
- 05 Prepare students for entrepreneurship as well as placement.

Employers and industry

- 01 Invest in onboarding and continuous upskilling, not only in hiring.
- 02 Share workforce intelligence with academia and skilling bodies.
- 03 Train mid-career professionals to apply AI in their own domains.
- 04 Prioritise enterprise and agentic AI that solves everyday problems.
- 05 Buy and pilot Indian AI products to build domestic demand.

Government and the skilling ecosystem

- 01 Build live workforce market intelligence to guide skilling.
- 02 Plan AI readiness sector by sector.
- 03 Strengthen credible assessment and certification.
- 04 Encourage patient capital for deep-tech and product start-ups.
- 05 Use public systems and procurement to help Indian AI products scale.
- 06 Pursue capability across the stack, from compute to applications.

CLOSING PERSPECTIVE

The race has just begun

The panel offered no easy reassurance. The readiness gap is real, campus placements are under pressure, and India still consumes far more AI than it creates.

Yet every panellist also saw opportunity: in manufacturing and every business function, in sector-specific and agentic applications, in India's own unsolved problems, and in the sharply lower cost of building something new.

Closing the gap is a shared task. Universities must teach students to question and to build. Employers must invest in the people they hire. Skilling bodies must track how work is changing. Government must send clear signals for research and products. And students, for their part, now hold an advantage no earlier generation had: access to knowledge and tools that were once the preserve of large institutions.

The conversation continues at the Bharat AI Innovation Conference and Exhibition at the World Trade Center Mumbai on 20 to 21 November 2026, and across further Campus Series panels in the months ahead.



"This race has just begun, and we are not late."

Bhupesh Daheria, CEO, Aegis School of Data Science & AI



"AI is looking like a monster to many of us. But the biggest challenge right now is the changing dynamics of the job market."

Priyanka Srivastava, Senior Editor, Education Times

ABOUT

The Campus Series and its organisers



Bharat AI Innovation 2026

A national initiative inspired by the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047. The 2026 edition brings 5,000+ researchers, founders, CXOs and policymakers to the World Trade Center Mumbai on 20 to 21 November 2026, with a multi-track conference, an exhibition across industry zones and an AI Impact Showcase. Visitor passes are free. Register at bharataiinnovation.com/register.

Campus Series

Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series

Free pre-event panels on campuses across India that bring industry, academia and policy together, with a large share of time for student questions. After Dwarkadas J. Sanghvi College of Engineering, Mumbai, and Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi, more campuses are being confirmed. Host a panel: bharataiinnovation.com/campus-series.



Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi

Host institution, through its School of Computational and Integrative Sciences.



Atal Incubation Centre, JNU Foundation for Innovation (AIC-JNUFI)

Incubation partner for the session.



Aegis School of Data Science & AI

India's first school to launch a PGP in Data Science, in 2015, with over 43 batches of data science professionals graduated since. Aegis works on AI and data science for social good and governance, and runs an AI Product Factory whose projects include:

- **Khozo:** tracking child and women trafficking
- **Savnadi:** protecting water bodies
- **Aarakshak:** a sovereign AI system for proctoring, surveillance and KYC, built with Assessfy
- **Pothole detection:** for safer roads

Aegis Knowledge Trust organises Bharat AI Innovation, the Aegis Graham Bell Awards and the Data Science Congress.



Assessfy

The AI Operating System for Continuous Improvement, helping universities and institutions digitise examinations, outcome-based education and accreditation.



mUniCampus

Digital infrastructure for learning organisations, whether a university, a college or a corporate.



Aegis Graham Bell Awards

Presented by Aegis Knowledge Trust, the awards have honoured innovation across 17 editions since 2008. bellaward.com

CONTINUE THE CONVERSATION

Join us at Bharat AI Innovation 2026

World Trade Center Mumbai, 20 to 21 November

Watch the full JNU panel, explore upcoming Campus Series sessions, or invite the series to your campus.



Watch the panel

youtube.com/watch?v=y6hPsmX4u0w



Campus Series

bharataiinnovation.com/campus-series

ONLINE

bharataiinnovation.com

Register free for the conference and exhibition

bharataiinnovation.com/register



This publication summarises views expressed by panellists and audience members at a Bharat AI Innovation Campus Series event held at Jawaharlal Nehru University, New Delhi. Views are those of the individuals concerned and do not necessarily represent the views of their organisations, the host institution or the organisers. Figures are as cited during the discussion and have not been independently verified. Quotes have been lightly edited for clarity. © 2026 Aegis Knowledge Trust. All rights reserved.